

PRODUCERS VS MULTIPLEXES

FRONT STALLED

Producers and multiplexes fight over revenue sharing as movie theatres across the country run on empty

Good business is like good sex. Both partners have to achieve satisfaction, says Mahesh Bhatt. By that token, Bollywood sex has been very unsatisfactory. Producers/distributors have been complaining of being robbed of their just profits by multiplexes who contribute 40 per cent to domestic theatrical revenue though their 750 screens are outnumbered by the 10,000-odd single screens. Producers have been asking for a 50 per cent share of revenues, with no sliding scale, as well as a say in the distribution strategy. Sixty-five meetings have been held so far between and among the producers and multiplexes (Big Cinemas, PVR, Fun Republic, INOX, Fame and Cinemax) at a cost of Rs 70 lakh, at locations varying from Mumbai's suburban Sun-n-Sand Hotel to the Taj Land's End. The meetings have seen almost-walkouts by Shah Rukh Khan and Aamir Khan over the sliding scale as well as great humour—varying from Aamir smsing Shah Rukh the wrong time for a meeting so he would make it in time to the voluble Vidhu Vinod Chopra drawing attention to himself when he would keep quiet for more than 15 minutes at a time. The end result may well fall short of what the producers want, a 50 per cent share in the revenues for the full run of their movies. Producers have agreed to 50 per cent in the first week, 42.5 per cent in the second week, 37.5 in the third week and 30 in the fourth week, while multiplexes were willing to sign on just 50 per cent, 40 per cent, 35 per cent and 30 per cent respectively. As Siddharth Roy Kapur, CEO, UTV Motion Pictures, says: "On a Rs 100 ticket with a Rs 30 entertainment tax, we were getting just 43 per cent of Rs 70. At least now we can hope to get 48 per cent." Whatever the final agreement, the show of unity within the 400-strong member United Producers and Distributors Forum has kept the industry in high spirits in the midst of a meltdown. And with Shah Rukh and Aamir back on backslapping terms, everyone is feeling friendlier. No mention of dogs allowed.



MEMBERS OF THE UNITED PRODUCERS AND DISTRIBUTORS FORUM AT A PRESS CONFERENCE



stars! Hey, not so fast. It can all wait. Even though the multiplex-producers stand-off looks like winding down, Bollywood, where the neon lights were never switched off, has become a dead zone of reputations and declarations. *Blue*, directed by newbie Anthony D'Souza and produced by Shree Ashtavinayak, made for Rs 100 crore, is waiting to be bought by a distributor. *London Dreams*, at a budget of Rs 60 crore, made by the Punjabi diaspora's adopted Gujarati Vipul Shah, was almost signed up for Rs 120 crore by Indian Films but will now have trouble getting more than the Rs 80 crore being offered to it right now. The T-Series' film with Salman Khan, where they were paying him Rs 40 crore plus a percentage of profits, has been scrapped. As has Percept's *Come On Pappu*, a Rs 60-crore film to be directed by David Dhawan's son, starring Akshay Kumar. Even Karan Johar's Rs 88-crore *My Name is Khan*, which includes a fee of Rs 10 crore each for star Shah Rukh Khan and director Johar, currently shooting in the bay area of San Francisco, will struggle to get a generous buyer, while Raju Hirani's Rs 75-crore *3 Idiots*, which is to complete the last 10 per cent of its filming on Delhi

LONDON DREAMS Rs 60 crore

STARRING Salman Khan, Ajay Devgan, Asin

HYPE Think *Hum Dil De Chuke Sanam* set in a band from the underground bhangra scene in London. Salman loves Asin. Ajay loves Asin. Who does Asin love? Hmm?

HOPE Salman as a singer? Yuvraaj redux?

RECESSION INDEX Was about to be picked up by Indian films for Rs 120 crore. Difficult to get even Rs 80 crore now.